the park authorities to rush veterinary aid from the Kanha and Pench national parks and the School of Wildlife Forensics and Health in Jabalpur to the spot.

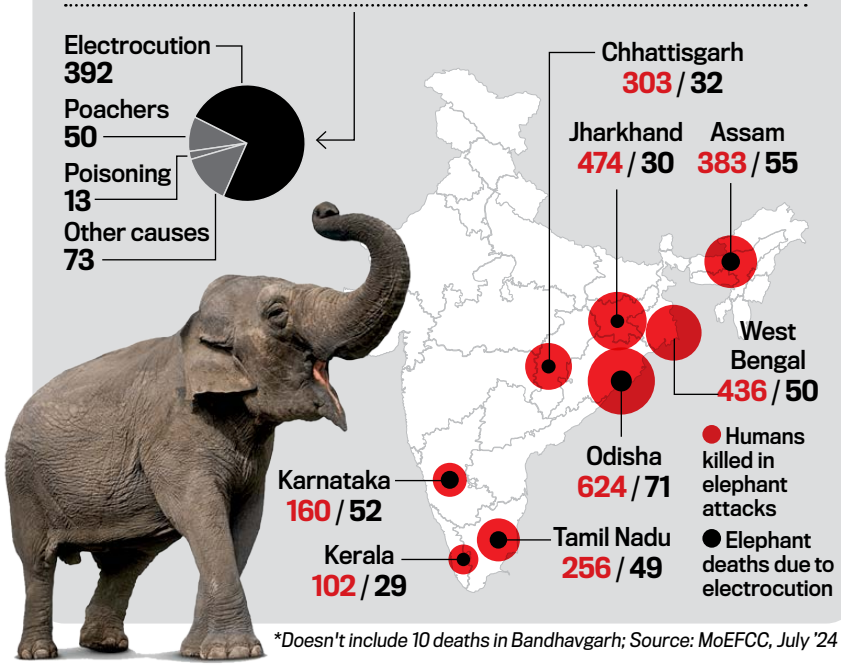
When the teams reached, the scene left them shaken. Separated by a few metres, four elephants lay dead, while another six, out of a herd of 13, were on the ground, writhing in pain. The remaining three healthy elephants, driven by a protective spirit, wouldn't let the vets—almost a dozen of them—approach. Crackers were burst to drive the three away and IV fluids administered, standard treatment in cases of poisoning. As it turned dark, the operation continued in the headlights of vehicles. At the end of the long night, 10 elephants, or nearly 25 per cent of the estimated 40 pachyderms that have made the park their home in the past six years, were dead. "The elephants were trying to raise their heads in a sign of seeking help but would collapse almost immediately," says Dr Nitin Gupta, the vet at Bandhavgarh and a first responder. "We administered fluids to the unwell ones and were in touch with vets from other colleges to get leads on treatment options. One ranger also suffered a fracture while helping out in treatment." Some of the jumbos who died, he adds, were sub-adults.

Two simultaneous investigations were immediately launched, one by the state's wildlife wing and another by the Centre's Wildlife Crime Control Bureau (WCCB). Preliminary inquiries found that the elephants had raided the crops at Salkhania the previous night. A search began for possible evidence of poisoning but did not yield anything. But the post-mortem and questioning of locals threw up an interesting lead. Encouraged by the government and better prices, the locals had started sowing kodo millet in the area, replacing the staple paddy. A large part of the post-harvest produce was lying out in the open and had become soggy

TUSKER TRAVAILS

528* Unnatural elephant deaths in last 5 years

2,829 Humans killed in elephant attacks (Mar '19-Mar '24)



*Doesn't include 10 deaths in Bandhavgarh; Source: MoEFCC, July '24

FOREST OFFICIALS SAY UNLESS ELEPHANT HABITATS ARE KEPT SACROSANCT, LITTLE CAN BE DONE; THEY WILL COME OUT IN SEARCH OF FOOD EVENTUALLY

in the rains. This could have resulted in the growth of fungi on the kodo seeds, leading to a situation of kodo poisoning—known among the resident Gond community as 'malona'. But the sceptics did not digest the kodo poisoning theory—Opposition leader of the Congress, Umang Singhar, even referenced Lord Ganesha while questioning the findings. Not entirely off the back foot, CM Mohan Yadav suspended the field director and a sub-divisional forest officer for dereliction of duty. On the subplot side, it wasn't the best time to be ambushed in the jungle: state forest minister Ram Niwas Rawat is contesting a byelection necessitated by his own defection.

Finally, on November 5, the Bareilly-based Indian Veterinary Research Institute confirmed kodo poisoning as the cause of death. "Kodo millet poisoning has happened among elephants in the past too [the first incident was reported in 1922 in Shahjahanpur in UP], but the fact that 10 elephants died out of a population of 40 in the habitat is a major setback," says Dr Raman Sukumar, one of India's foremost authorities on elephants and National Science Chair at the Centre for Environmental Sciences, Indian Institute of Science. The fungi apparently develop in wet weather, percolate the skin of the kodo seed and become a mycotoxin.

Whether there is a criminal angle or not, the fact is that man-elephant conflict is increasing, not just in Bandhavgarh, but in almost all elephant-bearing areas in the country. Three days after the incident, on November 2, two men were trampled to death and a third injured in Bandhavgarh, prompting comments that the pachyderms were seeking retribution for their dead.

According to the last census in 2017, India had 29,964 elephants, around 60 per cent of the world's jumbo population. In the past five years, 528 of them died of unnatural causes (see box, *Tusker Travails*). Between 2019 and 2024, 2,829 people were killed by the giant mammals.